

Hired Swords

This section covers new Hired Swords exclusive to the Empire in Flames wilderness setting. These new characters follow the generic rules for hiring and maintaining Hired Swords from page 147 of the Mordheim rulebook.

The Devil of the Drakwald

The forest gloom was like a death shroud in the creeping silence of the Drakwald. The arboreal void held the promise of dark imaginings, of bestial torture and debauched acts of inhuman lust. Seldom were the calls of birds heard, or an errant shaft of sunlight that had lost its way seen; even the breeze held the stink of blood. A man would be foolish indeed to wander such paths in the dark, to traverse such belligerent terrain without armoured escort or even a guide. And in spite of that a figure wandered there, along darkened pathways, scorched bracken crunching loudly underfoot, a miasma of blackness before him, the eyes of devils at his back...

"Man-flesh," Boraash, an inhuman Beastman growled in the murk of the undergrowth. Gorgoth snorted next to him, his hunched shoulders flexing at the prospect of battle, eyes narrowing with dark anticipation. A third, Kornak, licked the burgeoning saliva off his fangs and snout, raking the air impatiently with thick gnarled horns and uttered.

"Encircle him!"

The forest was thickening, all the while the outside world becoming ever more remote, all but a faded memory. And yet the traveller continued, seemingly unaware of the creatures stalking him.

Boraash sped quickly through the black bracken, sweeping past low lying branches, moving rapidly through thick foliage. The rest of his foul horde was a blur as they too raced ahead of their human prey. Boraash felt his shaggy mane twitch in anticipation. He could almost taste the blood he would soon drink.

A red haze overlaid Gorgoth's vision. Sharp and whipping tree limbs lashed at his face but they did not deter him, a frenzy was upon his very soul and he plunged headlong full of blood fevered zeal. Fangs bared, he was about to spring out in the open to tear the man-thing's flesh and devour it whole when a thick, sharpened stake pierced his gut, flung upwards from the forest bed.

Kornak's instincts had warned him to stay back, to remain in the wake of Boraash and Gorgoth. His animal eyes widened when he saw Gorgoth pitched into the air, a thick fountain of blood issuing from his back like black rain. Boraash had stalled, poised to attack. Kornak watched him slow, acutely aware that their prey had suddenly and abruptly disappeared...

Boraash sniffed the air, ears twitching, fear creeping upon him at the grim sight of Gorgoth, but he could find no trace of the man-thing's stench. He would feast on his brethren's carcass after he had bled the man-thing, he would suck the flesh from his bones, he would...

A silver-grey blur and a whistling in the trees silenced Boraash's intent. He fell back; a heavy bladed throwing axe embedded deep in his skull, thick, oily matter oozing down the haft.

Kornak snorted in fear as Boraash was thrown off his feet. His eyes darted back to the prone shape of Gorgoth, fur matting with his own blood. When he looked back, a figure was silhouetted against the gloom. At first he thought it was Boraash, somehow having survived the axe blade. But one of his horns was broken and he didn't smell right.

It was the traveller. He had come back.

"Man-thing!", Kornak roared in a feral rage, bursting through the branches and foliage as if they were nothing. He raised a crude, gore-splattered mace intent on pulping the man's skull like paste. He would eat the grey jelly within. But as Kornak swung for the killing blow the man-thing pulled a sharp axe as if from the forest air. Kornak felt his mace smash against the stout haft. There was a flash of silver in the man-thing's other hand. Like fire, something bit deep. Kornak felt warm blood flowing down his side and with dying bestial eyes looked upon the visage of his slayer and balked in terror. For there before him was a thing more bestial than his brethren, eyes burning with animal hatred, body swathed in the foul-smelling skins of his kin, daubed in unguents that burned Kornak's nose and mouth. He had encountered a devil, a devil of the woods, his nightmare; his scourge.

Vantigan allowed the foul body of the bestial spawn to slide like spoiled meat from his blade. Then, without pause he hacked off the creature's head with a single, powerful blow. In moments he had stripped it of flesh and other matter and rammed it deep upon a stake. It would make a fine trophy for his rack. But he had other prey that yet eluded him in these woods. Night was close and that would bring it into the open. These beastmen had been lured and vanquished easily. The balewolf would not nearly be as straight forward...

The Myth of the Balewolf

Lashing rain poured out of the blackness and lightning tore ragged strips in the sky as a lone traveller slowly wandered injured and dying to the little known village of Högenbath. A benevolent people, the villagers of Högenbath, rushed the stranger to the local apothecary, who tended to his wounds. Through cracked lips, with the last of his breath, he told the apothecary he was attacked on the road by a wolf but that it was no ordinary beast. A huge apparition as if from the depths of the pit itself, it held the gait of a man rather than a beast. In the frantic struggle that followed he had fought the creature off, piercing its heart with his broken sword but not before he had been badly wounded in return. Upon that remark he fell unconscious...

Regarding the ashen pallor of his charge, the apothecary feared the worst, convinced he would not last the night.

As daylight broke, the apothecary awoke and found to his amazement that miraculously the man's wounds had completely healed! The day passed without event as the traveller was welcomed by the entire village, his strength recovered, but the following night the true horror of what had taken place was revealed and Sigmar's hand had no part in it...

Once again, the moon waxed full. A watchman, was conducting his nightly patrols when he was alerted by the sounds of screaming across the village square. Rain was falling and thunder rolled across the growing cloud as he bolted through the downpour to the apothecary's abode from where the terrible sounds were emanating.

The door was rent from its hinges and splintered wood lay all about like bone as the wind and rain whipped within. Inside, a broken lantern swung frenziedly from the ceiling. It illuminated a dark and terrible vista which the watchman would take to his grave. His blood splattered upon the walls, the village apothecary was little more than a partially devoured corpse, steaming in the night chill.

He had been slain by some terrible beast, a nightmare made flesh. As if in answer, a low, ululating howl rang out through the storm and dark silhouette was stark against the white slashes of lightning. The monster was huge, akin to a wolf and yet not so. As quickly as it was revealed it disappeared in the forest gloom beyond, lost into myth.

Of the traveller no sign was ever found.

Beast Hunter

The Beast Hunter is a dark wanderer, full of mystery and self-loathing. His is a woeful tale. Kith and kin slaughtered by the foul Beastmen of the wild. He is one of many such men who have been driven to the very edge by their experiences, yearning only now for unquenchable revenge against those that destroyed their once normal lives. They bedeck themselves in the skins of their foes and take on a truly frightening aspect. It is a stout captain indeed who hires such 'wild men' of the forest but their hunter's skills are without equal and their raw strength in combat is too awesome to ignore. Dangerous and ferocious, ideal qualities for survival in the dark, unbridled wilds...

Hire Fee: 35 Gold Crowns to hire + 15 Gold Crowns upkeep.

May be Hired: Any warband other than Skaven, Beastmen, Undead, Orcs & Goblins, Possessed and Carnival of Chaos may hire a Beast Hunter.

Rating: A Beast Hunter increases the warband's rating by +18 points, plus 1 point for each Experience Point he has.

Profile	M	WS	BS	S	T	W	I	A	Ld
Beast Hunter	4	3	4	3	3	1	4	2	7

Equipment: Two axes, throwing axe (counts as a throwing knife with +1 Strength), light armour.

SPECIAL RULES

Beastmen Vengeance: The Beast Hunter hates all Beastmen (this includes Gors, Ungors, Centigors and Minotaurs) and will fight for no upkeep cost in battles against Beastmen.

Skull Rack: The Beast Hunter wears a grisly skull rack bedecked with bestial skulls. He causes *fear* in all Beastmen.

Predator: The Beast Hunter is a predator of all fell creatures but most especially Beastmen. In any battle that is set in the wilderness (ie. not within Mordheim) that involves Beastmen, the Beast Hunter may be set up after both warbands have deployed. He may be set up anywhere on the board that is hidden and outside of the enemy deployment zone.

Skills: A Beast Hunter may choose from Combat and Strength skills when he gains a new skill.

The Thing in the Woods

The 'Thing' is a creature encounter for the *Empire in Flames* setting as detailed in the scenario 'The Thing in the Woods' on page 42.

Profile	M	WS	BS	S	T	W	I	A	Ld
Balewolf	5	4	0	5	5	3	4	2(3)	7

SPECIAL RULES

Large Beast: The Balewolf is a huge creature and counts as a large target for the purposes of shooting and may be targeted even if it isn't the closest model.

Fear: The Balewolf is a terrible and frightening creature that causes *fear*.

Forged by Chaos: A creation of Chaos; the Balewolf was born from some nefarious yet unknown origin. The power of Chaos knits its form together when it is wounded and as such the Balewolf has the ability to supernaturally heal itself. At the start of each of its turns roll a D6 if the Balewolf is wounded. On a roll of 5+ one Wound is restored as its skin miraculous knits back together.

Flesh of Iron: The Balewolf's skin is thicker than toughened leather, wholly capable of turning aside blades and arrows alike. The Balewolf has an Armour save of 4+ which is reduced by the Strength of the attack as normal.

Vicious Jaws: The Balewolf's massive jaws are capable of crushing a man's body in two. The Balewolf has an extra Attack from its jaws (as denoted in its profile) which is always its first attack. If this attack hits, it causes a critical hit on a roll of 5 or 6.

Lycanthrope: The blood of the Balewolf contains a terrible and powerful curse. Any model taken out of action from an attack from the Balewolf risks the taint of its dark blood (note that this only affects man-sized creatures and non-mutants). After the battle, if the model survives the attack, roll a D6. On a roll of a 6 any injuries the model is currently suffering are cured but they are now cursed!

In each subsequent battle whenever the cursed model is wounded they must take a Leadership test. If they fail they transform horrifically

before the eyes of their comrades into the Balewolf! The model now has the same stat-line as the Balewolf. Any armour or equipment it was wearing is destroyed and any weapons the model was carrying are lost but may be recovered after the battle. The Balewolf will always charge the nearest model, friend or foe, if it can, otherwise it will move at maximum speed towards them. It may try and restrain itself from attacking a comrade by taking a test against his own Leadership (he may not use the leader's). If passed, the Balewolf will ignore friendly models.

Roll a D6 after the battle. On a roll of 2-6 the model returns to normal (albeit without attire...) but still carries the curse. On a roll of 1, the Balewolf takes hold completely and in his feral state disappears into the wilderness lost forever in myth and legend (remove from roster).

Highwayman

Roaming the woods and secluded byways of the Empire, highwaymen prey on the many coaches and wagons foolish or desperate enough to travel there. These are dark and dangerous men, often employed for their knowledge of cargo charters and skill at ambush. Oft they appear to the naked eye, bereft of their blackened garb, as foppish, charming characters, but that ruse is a genteel masquerade as their cruelty and viciousness will testify. Deadly pistoliers and expert riders, they are an asset to any warband but watch your back, for they are untrustworthy, self-serving men.

Hire Fee: 35 Gold Crowns to hire + 20 Gold Crowns upkeep.

May be Hired: Any warband, except Sisters of Sigmar, Witch Hunters and any good-aligned Elves may hire a Highwayman. A Highwayman will never join a warband that also contains a Roadwarden.

Rating: A Highwayman increases the warband's rating by +20 points, plus 1 point for each Experience Point he has.

Profile	M	WS	BS	S	T	W	I	A	Ld
Highwayman	4	3	4	3	3	1	3	1	7
Horse	8	0	0	3	3	1	3	0	5

Weapons/Armour: Brace of pistols, rapier (p.84 Mordheim Annual), cloak (acts as a buckler in close combat) and dagger.

If you are using the optional rules for mounted models then the Highwayman also rides a horse.

When the Highwayman is mounted, he has a save of 6+, on foot he has no Armour save.

Skills: A Highwayman may choose from Combat, Shooting and Speed skills when he gains a new skill.

SPECIAL RULES

Expert Pistolier: A Highwayman's skill with a brace of pistols is unrivalled and as such he combines the effects of the skills Pistolier and Trick Shooter.

Unscrupulous: A Highwayman, despite all his skill and bravado, is not to be trusted. At the end of each battle roll a

D6, on a roll
of a 1 the
warband
receives 1
less piece of
Treasure than they
would normally as the
Highwayman has stolen it
for himself (this Treasure is not
spent on the Highwayman, it is
lost!). Obviously, if this keeps
happening it will be up to
warband leader to keep the
Highwayman in his employ or
not...

Expert Rider: A Highwayman is a superb rider and as such while he is mounted he counts as being stationary for the purposes of shooting (ie. no -1 modifier to hit) and he also benefits from the skill as he can reload quickly whilst on horseback.

Roadwarden

Patrolling the fraught and dangerous highways of the Empire, Roadwardens are dour men of the sternest courage. Solitary figures, they range far and wide, often with little food and in all weathers. They are hardened and brutal fighters, uncompromising and without any martial code, they give no quarter as they expect none to be given in return. Their skill lies with the crossbow, with which they are excellent hunters and deadly marksmen. Highwaymen, deviants and bandits are their common quarry, safety of the roadways their charge and they execute both with deliberate and unswerving severity.

Hire Fee: 40 Gold Crowns to hire + 20 Gold Crowns upkeep.

May be Hired: Any good-aligned warband may hire a Roadwarden such as Witch Hunters, Sisters of Sigmar, Dwarfs and Human Mercenaries. A Roadwarden will never join a warband that also contains a Highwayman.

Rating: A Roadwarden increases the warband's rating by +22 points, plus 1 point for each experience point he has.

Profile	M	WS	BS	S	T	W	I	A	Ld
Roadwarden	4	3	4	3	3	1	3	1	8
Horse	8	0	0	3	3	1	3	0	5

Weapons/Armour: Crossbow, horseman's hammer (p.14 Town Cryer 24), dagger, heavy armour and three torches (p.14 Town Cryer 24). If you are using the optional rules for mounted models then the Roadwarden also rides a horse. The Roadwarden's save is 4+ whilst mounted and 5+ whilst on foot.

Skills: A Roadwarden may choose from Combat, Strength and Shooting skills when he gains a new skill.

SPECIAL RULES

Lethal Marksman: A master with the crossbow, a Roadwarden combines the skills of Trick Shooter and Eagle Eyes.

Stern: Working alone and in the dark for the majority of his

profession the Roadwarden is made of strong stuff indeed. He may re-roll any failed Leadership test for panic, fear, and is immune to the rules for being All Alone.

Expert Rider: A highly skilled horseman, a Roadwarden counts as having the Nimble skill whilst on horseback and suffers no modifiers for moving and shooting.

STAGECOACHES

Both Highwaymen and Roadwardens are particularly suited to battles involving stagecoaches, wagons, etc. To represent this, in any scenario in which one or both sides have a stagecoach or a wagon, any Highwayman or Roadwarden in either warband may re-roll a single dice roll once per turn. This special bonus lasts until the re-rolled dice comes up as a 1 as it is designed to represent their ability to predict and perform at their peak in familiar and well-practiced territory.